

COMMON GROUND

How Chicagoans discover, reach, and return to culture

A report about access, designed as an access point.

Portfolio note. Common Ground is a self-directed editorial design exercise. It combines public-source context with an illustrative survey model created to demonstrate long-form typography, information design, photography, tables, timelines, footnotes, and print-production thinking. It is not an official City of Chicago report and should not be read as original research.

CONCEPT, WRITING, DESIGN, AND DATA MODEL: JOCELYN MARTINEZ

FORMAT: 8.5 × 11 IN · 28 PAGES · PERFECT-BOUND CONCEPT

Common Ground

2026 Cultural Access Report

How people notice, understand, reach, and return to cultural experiences across a city.

The publication moves from public-source context to an illustrative participation model, community stories, design recommendations, and a transparent methodology.

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Evidence needs a reading order.

A report becomes useful when the reader can move between overview, detail, and action without losing the thread.

What is public context?

Chicago has 77 community areas, and the city's cultural agency frames access as a neighborhood-wide responsibility. The 2023 DCASE Impact Report describes grants and programs distributed across all 50 wards, while the National Endowment for the Arts tracks participation and barriers at a national scale.

What is illustrative?

The survey percentages, regional comparisons, quotes, and journey model in this publication are fictional scenario data. They are designed to make the editorial system behave like a real report without misrepresenting a study that did not occur.

How should it be read?

Begin with the opening spread for the core argument, use the data pages to scan patterns, then move into stories and recommendations for interpretation. Sources and limitations appear near the end rather than being hidden.

01 / OPENING

Access is not a single doorway.

Culture is often described as a collection of institutions, events, and objects. Access is more ordinary than that.

It begins with whether a person notices an invitation, understands what is being offered, can reach it within the time and money available, and feels that the experience is meant for them.

This report treats participation as a sequence rather than a single attendance number. Information, transportation, pricing, social comfort, and welcome all shape whether interest becomes action.



01

NOTICE

Can I find it?

02

UNDERSTAND

Is it for me?

03

ARRIVE

Can I reach it?

04 / P

04

BELONG

Will I return?



THE PARTICIPATION JOURNEY

A cultural experience is shaped before the visitor crosses the threshold. Discovery, expectation, route planning, cost, and welcome all belong to the same communication problem.

02 / BY THE NUMBERS

Participation at a glance

Illustrative survey model · n = 600 adults · four city regions · designed for information-design demonstration only.

68%

attended at least one
cultural event in the
modeled year

34%

attended an event
outside their home
region

21%

created or performed
art in a community
setting

16%

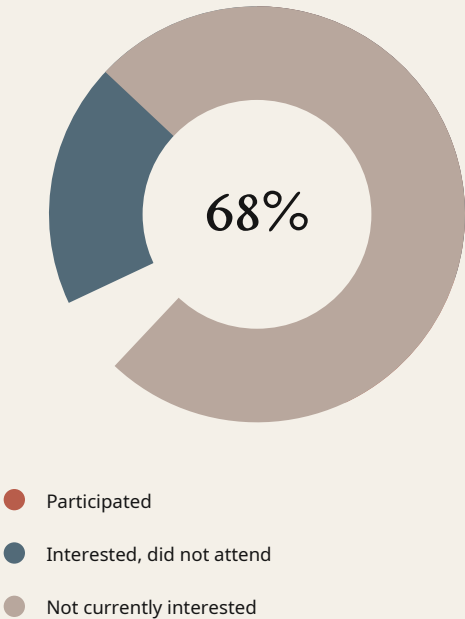
volunteered for a
cultural organization

READING THE FIGURES

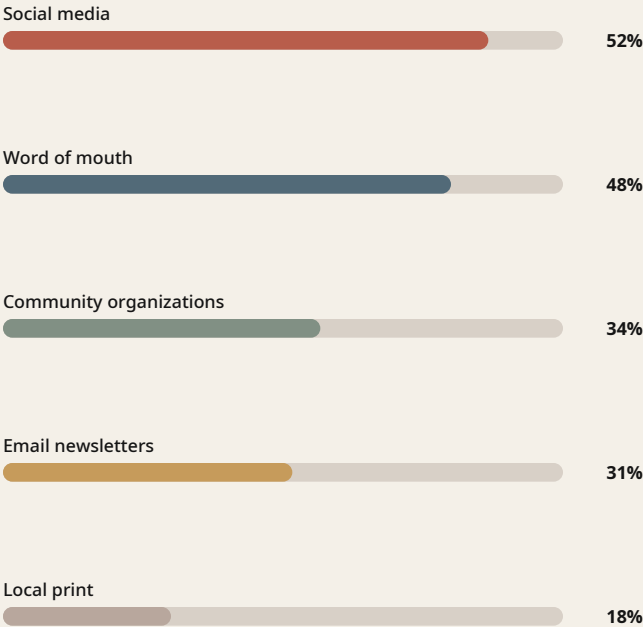
The model separates attendance from making, volunteering, and cross-neighborhood participation. Those behaviors overlap, but each requires different communication and service support.

02 / BY THE NUMBERS

How people participate



Where invitations arrive



In the illustrative model, trusted relationships and neighborhood institutions often acted as translators: they explained what an event was, not only that it existed.

03 / LONG-FORM ARTICLE

The geography of attention

People do not discover culture from a neutral starting point. Information travels through existing habits, relationships, and places.

A city can contain extraordinary cultural resources and still make them difficult to find. The gap is not always a shortage of programming. It is often a shortage of legible invitation: unclear event descriptions, fragmented calendars, unfamiliar language, weak transit information, or imagery that never signals who is welcome. In the illustrative model used for this report, discovery was strongest when information arrived through trusted social relationships or neighborhood organizations. Those channels did more than announce an event. They translated it.

TRANSLATION IS PART OF ACCESS

The design implication is practical. A campaign should not assume that the audience already knows the venue, the art form, or the expected behavior. Strong communication answers basic questions early: What will happen? How long will it last? What does it cost? Can I bring children? What should I expect when I arrive? The more unfamiliar the experience, the more important this orientation becomes.

A legible invitation reduces uncertainty without flattening the character of the experience. It gives the reader enough structure to imagine themselves attending.

QUESTIONS A FIRST-TIME VISITOR MAY ASK

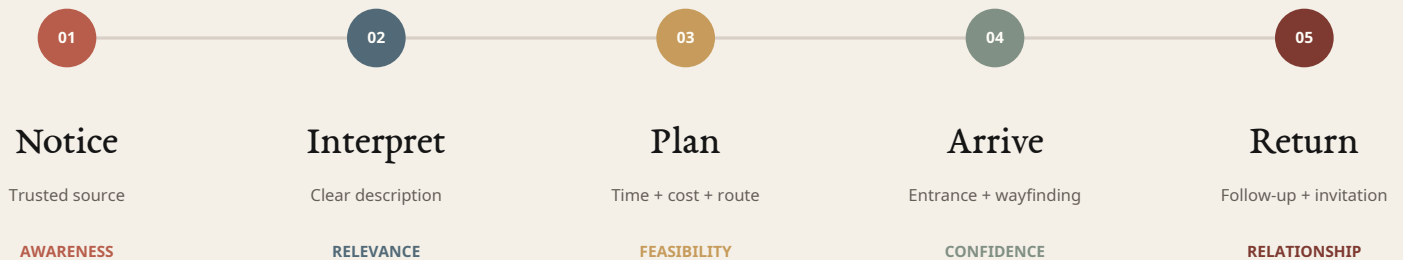
- What will happen?
- How long will it last?
- What does it cost?
- Can I bring children?
- What should I expect on arrival?

“Did the information make a decision easier?”¹

1. Survey statements and participant voices are illustrative scenario content.

One decision, many thresholds

The same person can move forward at one stage and stop at the next. The journey is continuous, but the communication task changes.



WHERE DESIGN CAN INTERVENE

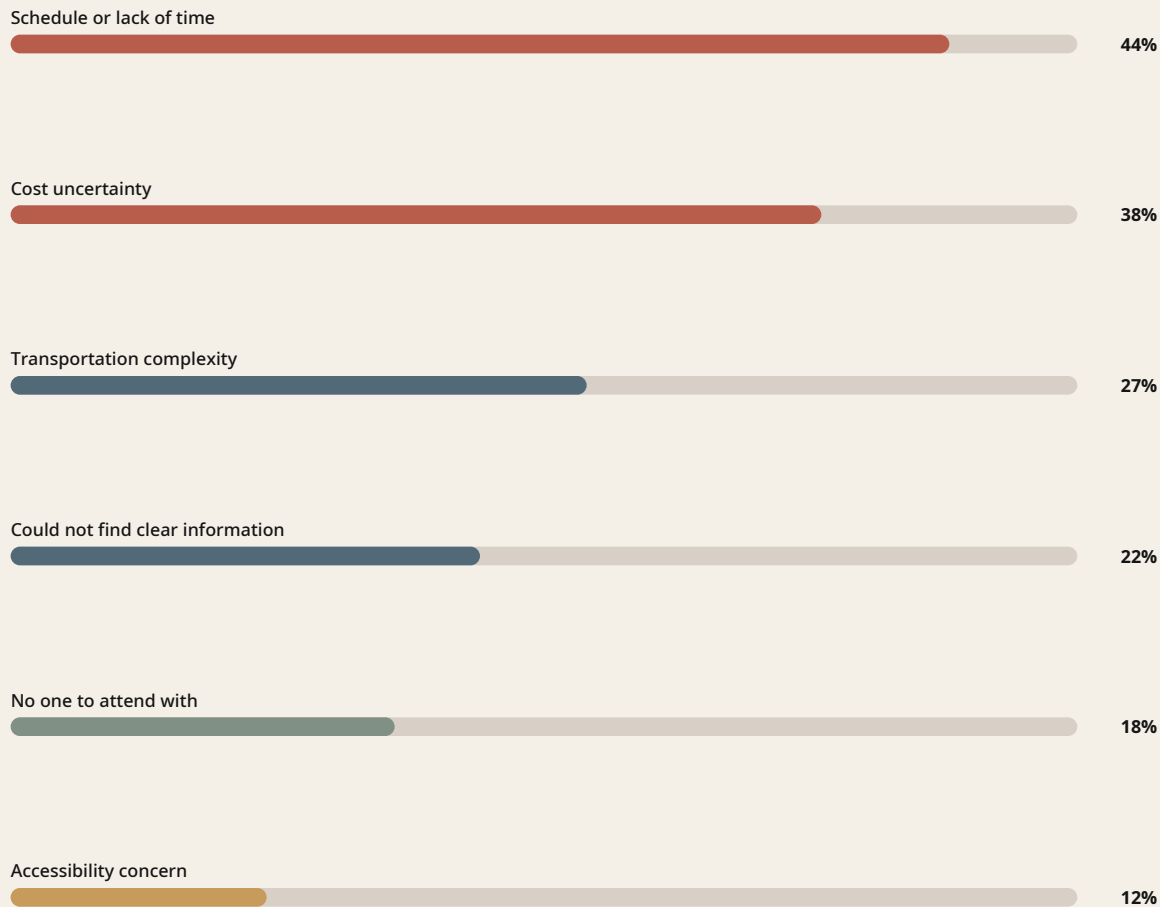
At each threshold, the system can reduce a different kind of uncertainty. A calendar supports noticing. Audience language supports interpretation. Route and cost information support planning. Environmental cues support arrival. A follow-up invitation supports return.



04 / BARRIERS

What keeps people away

Among respondents who expressed interest but did not attend, barriers accumulated rather than appearing alone.

**DESIGN IMPLICATION**

A venue cannot solve every barrier, but it can reduce uncertainty: publish total cost, transit and parking details, duration, access information, family policies, and what the visitor should expect on arrival.

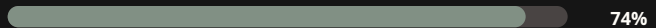


A CLOSER LOOK

Distance is not only miles.

Distance is measured in minutes, transfers, uncertainty, and the energy required to recover from a disrupted plan. Two venues may be the same number of miles away and feel completely different to reach. For a first-time visitor, the route is part of the experience. The report therefore treats transportation, schedule fit, and arrival information as design content rather than operational footnotes.

Under 30 minutes



30–60 minutes



More than 60 minutes



Illustrative likelihood of attendance by one-way travel time.

05 / PHOTO ESSAY

Four thresholds

The physical environment tells visitors whether to continue, pause, ask, or turn back.



01 / ARRIVAL



02 / ORIENTATION



03 / PAUSE



04 / INVITATION

05 / PHOTO ESSAY

Space communicates before the label does.

Arrival

The first view should reveal where to go next without overwhelming the visitor with every instruction at once.

Orientation

Repeated visual cues make a route feel intentional. Their role is reassurance, not decoration.

Pause

Seating, quiet zones, and readable interpretation allow people to regulate the pace of the experience.

Invitation

Photography, language, and staff presence signal who is expected and how participation can begin.



06 / VOICES

West Side voices

Illustrative participant statements used to demonstrate quote hierarchy, captions, and story pacing.

01

“I decide faster when the post tells me what the night will actually feel like.”

MARA, 28 · AUSTIN

02

“Free is helpful, but I still need to know the train ride home will be simple.”

DERRICK, 42 · NORTH LAWNSDALE

03

“The first time I went, someone greeted me before I had to ask where to stand.”

WHAT THE VOICES REVEAL

People describe access as a feeling of predictability: knowing the atmosphere, the route, and what will happen when they arrive.



STORY DESIGN

A quote should change the pace.

Narrative pages interrupt the statistical rhythm and remind the reader that barriers are experienced as moments: a confusing route, an uncertain price, a warm greeting, a reason to return.

A decade of neighborhood cultural investment

Selected public-source milestones provide context for the report's design scenario.

66%

of wards reached in 2016

94%

of wards reached in 2021

630+

grants awarded in 2022

749

grants awarded in 2023

2016

2021

2022

2023



Grant reach later reported at 66% of Chicago wards.

Grant reach increased to 94% of wards.

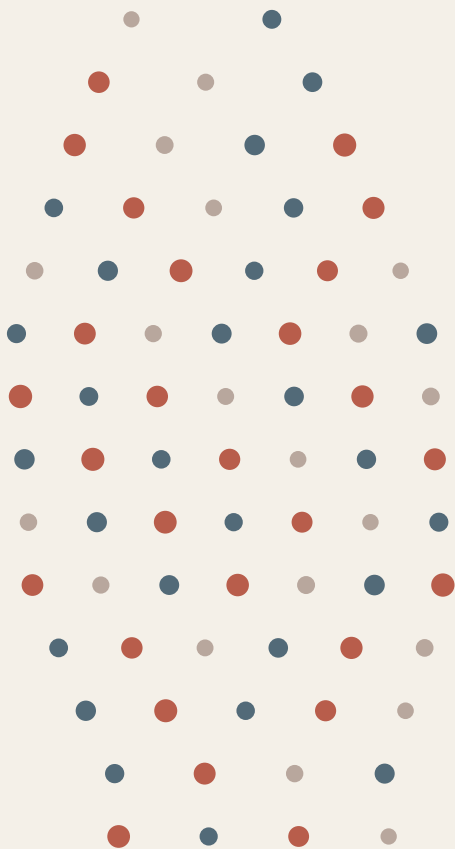
More than 630 grants; Neighborhood Access Program investment emphasized South and West Side projects.

More than \$23.5 million committed; grants awarded in all 50 wards.

Sources: City of Chicago DCASE 2022 and 2023 Impact Reports. These are contextual milestones, not results from the illustrative survey model.

Culture across 77 community areas

Chicago’s official community-area geography provides a useful frame for thinking about access, but geography alone cannot explain participation.



77
official community areas

50
wards reached by 2023 DCASE
grant awards

\$23.5M+
grant dollars committed by
DCASE in 2023

\$9.5M
to artists and organizations
on the South and West Sides
in 2023

Source context: City of Chicago Data Portal community-area boundaries; DCASE 2023 Impact Report.

08 / PROFILES

Different places need different invitations

Illustrative regional profiles show how the same campaign can fail for different reasons.

NORTH

High awareness · schedule pressure

Lead with duration, transit, and evening timing.

WEST

Strong community networks · lower institutional trust

Partner with neighborhood organizations and recognizable messengers.

SOUTH

High creation and volunteering · transportation

Connect events to local making and provide precise route information.

CENTRAL

High event density · choice overload

Use curation, comparison, and clear audience descriptions.

08 / DATA TABLE

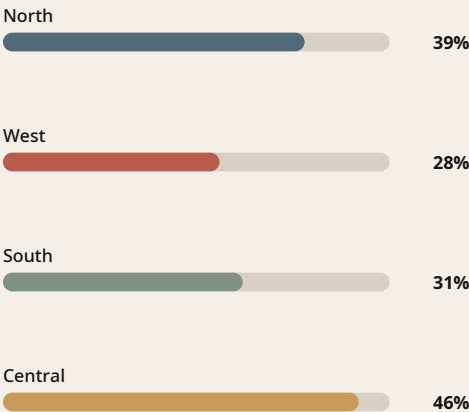
Modeled participation by region

Illustrative data · percentages are designed to demonstrate table hierarchy and tabular figures.

Region	Attended	Created	Volunteered	Cross-region
North	72%	18%	12%	39%
West	61%	24%	19%	28%
South	64%	27%	18%	31%
Central	78%	15%	9%	46%

What a table makes visible

Regional patterns are not rankings. They are prompts for communication choices: the campaign emphasis, partner mix, route information, and welcome language should change with context.



Design for the return visit

Belonging is also created through small signals. A clear greeting, visible staff, multilingual information, seating, accessible entrances, transparent pricing, and photographs that reflect the surrounding community can change whether someone returns. These are not decorative gestures. They are service standards that convert a successful first visit into an ongoing relationship.

01

NOTICE

Make the invitation visible and specific.

02

UNDERSTAND

Explain the experience, audience, cost, and duration.

03

ARRIVE

Reduce route, entrance, and wayfinding uncertainty.

04

BELONG

Create a welcome that continues after the first visit.

09 / SERVICE STANDARD

Belonging is designed

A repeatable service standard gives communications, operations, and environmental design a shared definition of welcome.

NOTICE

Make the invitation legible

- Name the audience
- Show what will happen
- Use trusted channels

UNDERSTAND

Reduce interpretation work

- Publish total cost
- State duration and format
- Explain access needs

ARRIVE

Confirm the route

- Clarify transit and parking
- Mark the entrance
- Offer visible staff cues

BELONG

Create a return path

- Reflect the community
- Support different pacing
- Invite the next action

10 / RECOMMENDATIONS

Six actions for clearer access

Recommendations translate the findings model into communication, service, and production tasks.

01 / CONTENT

Write the event before writing the campaign

Define audience, duration, cost, format, and access before visual production begins.

02 / AUDIENCE

Design for first-time attendance

Assume the reader does not know the venue, art form, or expected behavior.

03 / WAYFINDING

Treat route information as content

Show transit, parking, entrance, and arrival details where the decision is made.

04 / PARTNERS

Build neighborhood translation partners

Give community organizations reusable language, images, and formats.

05 / RETENTION

Create a return path

Offer another date, related program, membership, or volunteer invitation.

06 / MEASUREMENT

Measure clarity, not only reach

Track whether people understood the offer and completed the journey.

10 / IMPLEMENTATION

Start with the highest-friction moments

An impact-effort matrix helps teams decide what to improve first without turning the report into an unprioritized wish list.



Methodology, sources, and limits

Illustrative survey model

The model assumes 600 adult respondents distributed across four broad city regions. Percentages, profiles, and quotes are fictional scenario content built to demonstrate editorial hierarchy, tabular figures, chart design, and narrative integration.

Public-source context

Contextual facts draw from the City of Chicago Department of Cultural Affairs and Special Events 2022 and 2023 Impact Reports, the City of Chicago Data Portal community-area boundaries dataset, and the National Endowment for the Arts 2022 Survey of Public Participation in the Arts.

Limitations

The report is not representative research, does not evaluate specific organizations, and does not claim that the modeled percentages describe Chicago residents. It should be assessed as an editorial-design artifact.

Image treatment

Conceptual spatial imagery is used for layout demonstration. Images are consistently cropped, duotoned, captioned, and separated from statistical claims.

PUBLICATION PRODUCTION

TRIM	8.5 × 11 in	PAGES	28
BINDING	Perfect-bound concept	BLEED	0.125 in
MARGINS	0.70 / 0.78 in	GRID	12-column spread
BASELINE	14 pt	COLOR	CMYK production target
IMAGES	300 ppi effective	EXPORT	PDF/X-4 target

12 / CLOSING

Build for the return visit.

The strongest measure of access is not whether someone crossed the threshold once. It is whether the experience gave them enough clarity, comfort, and connection to imagine coming back.

Notice. Understand. Arrive. Belong.

A communication system can support each step.



